



DEPARTMENT OF POLITICAL SCIENCE

Course Report: Political Science Analysis SK2121 Fall semester 2024

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The course Political Science Analysis (SK2121) is a core course on the advanced level. It is the first course on the Master's Program in Political Science (MAPS) and the Master's Programme in Political Science: Environmental Governance and Behavior (MAPSE) and forms the introduction to these programmes.

Course coordinator is Frida Boräng, who is also responsible for the research area Comparative politics. The other teachers on the course are Lina Eriksson (Political theory), Victor Lapuente (Public administration) Nikolay Marinov (International politics), and Georgios Xezonakis (Political behavior). Jacob Gunderson works with academic writing support during the course, giving one lecture at the start of the course and providing individual tutorials for students seeking support.

The idea behind the course is to present an overview of Political Science. The course is organized around five research areas – Political Theory, Comparative Politics, Political Behavior, Public Administration and International Politics. Each bloc consists of three parts - a "base" lecture, two "research front" lectures, a voluntary "literature talk", and an examination seminar. The base lecture presents the background and development of the research area, as well as classical theories, concepts and findings. The research front lectures focus on selected actual research problems, based in current research. For each research area the students are presented seminar assignments in the form of three semi-selective themes or research problems which should be analyzed and discussed in a short research overview and discussed at the seminar, using the assigned literature. The examination of the course is based on each of these five papers and the seminars. There is also a voluntary literature talk between the lectures and the examining seminar, the idea being that the students would have had time to read most of the literature, but still be working on the written assignment. During the literature talks, students can come with their questions about the literature and discuss them together with fellow students and the responsible teacher. To ensure the relevance of the course for the MAPSE students, the goal is that one of the elective themes for each research area should be on environmental politics but this was not fully implemented for 2024.

The course is examined through five research overviews, one for each research area. In addition to the research reports the student must make one oral presentation of their research report and actively participate in all five compulsory seminars to pass the course. The five seminar papers are graded Fail (U), Pass (G), or Pass with Distinction (VG) and awarded 3 credits each. Failed seminar papers have to be completed following the teacher's instruction in order to reach the Pass level. In order to pass the course (G), the student needs to pass all the assignments. In order to pass the

course with distinction (VG), at least 3 of the seminar papers must have the grade VG and the rest of the assignments have the grade G.

During the fall semester 2024, 45 students were registered on the course (2 of these had re-registered). Of the 45, 41 had completed the course by February 2025. 20 students received the grade Pass (G) and 21 students Pass with Distinction (VG).

The students were asked to fill in the course evaluation after the course was completed. Out of 45 students who received the evaluation survey, 21 students responded (47%). The survey responses are attached. In addition to the survey, the course coordinator invited the students to an evaluation seminar the last day of the course. The seminar was very well attended and the students provided very helpful feedback. Below are results and comments from the survey and the evaluation seminar.

In general, the students evaluated the course positively: 95% of the students assess the course as either *Very good* (52%) or *Rather good* (43%). When asked to what degree the course helped the student to reach the learning outcomes, 33% answered *To a high degree* and 57% *To a fairly high degree*.

A challenge for the course is the diverse educational backgrounds of the students. Typically, MAPS students have a stronger foundation in political science from their bachelor's degrees compared to MAPSE students, for whom political science is not a prerequisite. It is not obvious how to strike a balance that accommodates both groups and the course can be more challenging for students without a political science background. From the comments in the evaluation survey:

I think the course was very well done, well structured and interesting. Coming from a political science bachelor I don't think the course was too challenging, but still a very helpful recap, and the lectures managed to keep the topics interesting.

Good lecturers, interesting topics, a little hard to follow in case you haven't studied political science before.

I'd say that a basic knowledge in Political Science prior to the course would be advantageous to reach the learning outcomes, but I also feel that I know a lot in the field after the course, and at least to some extent can meet the goals. Prior knowledge would give the students the ability to dive straight into the question at hand, while no prior knowledge require students to first learn the field and understand all the terms used, which frankly takes more time, which makes it harder to reach the learning outcomes.

Related to the difference between the programmes, students brought up both in the comments and in the evaluation seminar that more could be done to make the course relevant for MAPSE. For next time, we should therefore make sure that each research area offers an environmental theme that the students can choose, a goal that until now has not been fully implemented.

When evaluating the different teaching activities, students were generally happy with the lectures (*Very good* 43%, *Rather good* 57%), and the seminars (*Very good* 52%, *Rather good* 43%). The literature talks were also appreciated although a little less than lectures and examination seminars (*Very good* 37%, *Rather good* 37%). One point of discussion about the examination seminars is that the seminar groups are formed before students choose which topics to write on, which means that the distribution of themes written on, and therefore presentations given vary between seminars (i.e.,

in theory there can be three presentations about the same theme and none about the two others). This structure comes at a cost:

I liked to learn about the other themes by the presentations. But I think not every time we learned about each theme because that was not coordinated (who presents on what topic).

The students were overall very happy with the teachers (Very good 70%, Rather good 30%) which was also reflected in the comments:

Very friendly, with a will to teach students. I've had professors in previous courses that seems only interested in earning a paycheck while talking about something work related (they lack passion and the will to teach), but that's absolutely not the case in this course!

The students were more critical about the course literature, although most regarded it as Very good (29%) or Good (57%).

The examination in form of papers was generally appreciated (Very good 43%, Rather good 48%). The students were happy about the detailed feedback they got on their work:

I appreciate very much the written feedback.

I liked the extensive feedback

But at the same time (and related to the fact that the feedback is detailed) the students felt that faster feedback would be better:

Since it takes time to grade (very reasonable) it is a bit frustrating to get feedback on something you could have easily improved when you have already turned in two more assignments. Perhaps the papers could be shorter? That also makes the assignment harder though so it's a difficult balance.

The organization of the course was seen as working very well (Very good 52%, Rather good 48%). Students sometimes found that the teachers had somewhat different views on how to write the papers. We think it is important that the teachers are free to develop the assignments independently, but each of us could do more to clearly explain how we think about the assignment.

When it comes to workload, 48% found it OK, but 33% thought it was somewhat too demanding while 19% found it not that demanding. 52% reported that they worked 31-40 hours per week. 14% reported that they worked more than 40 hours per week, at the same time as 33% reported that they worked 11-30 hours per week. Overall, the workload seems reasonable:

In the beginning I was overwhelmed by the fast pace, but after the first assignment I'd gotten used to the tempo, and it proved to be very good. The course require one (me) to put in a lot of time, but since it's full time studies, I'd rather have that, then the other way around, with to much free-time.

The evaluation survey ends with an open question about whether students have experienced contexts or situations where they think there is a risk for harassment and discrimination. There were no such situations reported. These are all the comments on that question:

Good.

I did not perceive any risks of harassment or discrimination, neither towards myself nor my colleagues.

No, I haven't felt subject to discrimination, nor have I observed anything, deliberate or unintentional, from any school faculty member that puts students in difficult positions.